

Project 3: Technical Instructions - Group Project (draft 3% + final proposal 27 %) - total 30%

Overview

In teams, students will write, design, and revise a user-tested set of **technical “how-to” instructions** for a real-world task, tool, or process. Instructions must be accessible to novice users, visually clear, and refined through usability testing. Teams will plan and divide writing and design responsibilities and document their collaboration and revision process.

This project models workplace expectations: companies rely on collaborative technical writers to create accurate, usable, and professional documents.

Description

In both academic and professional settings, instructions are only useful if real users can successfully follow them. In the workplace, organizations depend on technical writers to create documentation that is clear, visually well-designed, consistent, and accessible, especially for novice users.

For this project, your team will create a professional instructional guide for a real-world process, tool, or task. Your guide must be:

- **Clear for novice users** (assume your reader has little or no prior knowledge)
- **Visually strong** (icons, diagrams, screenshots, and/or other graphics must improve clarity)
- **Usability tested**, meaning you have evidence that real people can follow your instructions successfully
- **Professionally formatted**, meeting the standards described in Open Technical Communication chapters on: Instructions (McMurrey & Race), User Guides (McMurrey & Powell), Usability Testing (Race)

Your team will write and revise multiple drafts, test the guide on users, document their feedback, and improve the final version accordingly.

Teamwork - Writing as a Group

Because this is a group project, your success depends on effective collaboration. Teams should assign roles early, set check-ins, and manage revision responsibly.

Roles to Assign

(roles may overlap, but everyone must contribute)

- **Project Manager:** sets deadlines, organizes meetings, ensures all parts integrate into one document
- **Content Writer(s):** drafts step-by-step instructions in plain language
- **Visual Designer(s):** creates diagrams, screenshots, Canva graphics, icons, labels
- **Editor(s):** ensures consistency, clarity, and tone across sections
- **Usability Coordinator:** organizes, runs, and documents usability testing

Group Norms

- Set weekly check-ins (in class or online)
- Decide how disagreements will be resolved (vote, rotate leadership, etc.)
- Keep versions saved to show evidence of revision and usability-driven improvements

AI Tools to Be Used

- Notebook LM will support teams in organizing research, creating outlines, and simplifying terminology.

- Google Gemini will help revise steps for clarity and accessibility and simulate how a new user might interpret each step. It can also generate custom visuals if needed.
- Canva will be used to design the final document with attention to readability, navigation, and visual appeal.
- Gamma.app or Tome.app may be used to develop a companion visual guide or slide walkthrough if the task benefits from multiple presentation formats.

Recommended Headings for the Instructional Guide

Your guide must follow professional technical writing conventions and include the following components (as applicable):

1. **Title Page** (clear task-focused title)
2. **Table of Contents**
3. **Introduction:** purpose; intended user/audience; scope (what is included / what is NOT included)
4. **Equipment / Materials List** - tools, supplies, software, accounts, prerequisites
5. **Step-by-Step Instructions**
 - numbered steps for sequential tasks
 - bulleted lists for options/items
 - consistent formatting and parallel wording
6. **Special Notices** - Warning (potential harm); Caution (prevent errors/damage); Note (tips / helpful reminders)
7. **Visuals Integrated Throughout**
 - screenshots, diagrams, icons, arrows/labels, before/after examples
 - every visual must have a caption (Figure 1, Figure 2, etc.)
8. **Troubleshooting Section**
 - anticipate common mistakes
 - explain clear, practical fixes
9. **Conclusion** - final outcome, next steps, support/contact info
10. **Optional Back Matter** - glossary, appendix, references

Writing Expectations (Professional Instructions)

Your guide should follow professional instruction-writing standards:

1. Imperative Mood - "Click Submit" (not "Submit should be clicked")
2. Short, direct sentences (avoid academic-style long paragraphs)
3. Concrete steps - avoid vague directions like "set it up properly"
4. Consistency - same verb form, formatting, and style throughout
5. Audience awareness - write for novices; avoid jargon or define it clearly

Usability Testing (Required)

Instructions are only professional if real users can follow them successfully. Your team must conduct usability testing and revise based on feedback.

Planning the Test

1. Choose tasks/sections to test
2. Recruit 3–5 testers unfamiliar with the task (novice users are ideal)
3. Prepare materials (draft guide, print or digital)

Running the Test

- welcome the tester and explain the purpose
- ask them to think aloud
- do not help them (observe confusion)
- record hesitations, skipped steps, errors, and questions

Documenting Results

- annotated drafts showing revisions and feedback
- notes/transcripts of tester comments
- both qualitative and quantitative evidence (ex: time-to-complete, # errors)

Revising from Feedback - Use test results to

- add missing steps
- clarify confusing language
- insert new visuals
- reorganize sequences

Deliverables

All deliverables should be submitted as one document in the following order:

1. Instructional Document (Final User Manual) - approx. 4–6 pages; must include visuals/icons/screenshots; must be professionally formatted and easy to navigate
2. Evidence of Usability Testing - notes, tester comments, annotated drafts, screenshots of revisions/feedback
3. Reflection Paper - Team reflection (1–2 pages): how roles were divided; how AI tools were used responsibly; what revisions were made after usability testing; how visuals/design improved clarity
4. Individual reflection paragraph (each student): your contribution; how AI supported your work; what you learned about collaboration and technical communication
5. Group Presentation (Required)

Your group will deliver a short overview of the instructional guide to the class. The format may be one of the following: a slide deck walkthrough, or a poster presentation, or a brief visual overview/demo of the manual. The presentation should summarize: the task/process your guide explains; key design choices (layout, visuals, navigation); what usability testing revealed; major improvements made after revision

Grading Rubric

Category	Excellent (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Incomplete (D/F)	Pts
Clarity of Instructions	Steps clear, logical, easy to follow; accessible for novices	Mostly clear & logical; minor lapses in accessibility	Some unclear/illogical steps; uneven accessibility	Confusing or incomplete steps	/5
Use of Visuals	Visuals (icons, screenshots, diagrams) enhance clarity; well-labeled & integrated	Relevant visuals; some integration or labeling issues	Weak/unclear visuals; poorly integrated	Missing or irrelevant visuals	/3
Formatting & Professionalism	Well-organized, professional, polished; minimal errors	Generally professional; minor errors	Some organization/formatting issues; frequent errors	Poorly formatted; many errors	/3
Usability Testing	Feedback well-documented & effectively incorporated; major clarity/accessibility gains	Feedback used with some improvements	Limited feedback integration; minor clarity gains	No evidence of feedback use	/5
Troubleshooting Section	Anticipates common issues; provides clear, practical solutions	Anticipates some issues; solutions somewhat clear	Few issues anticipated; limited solutions	No troubleshooting provided	/2
Group Presentation	Presentation is clear, well-paced, and professional; all group members contribute meaningfully; explains the task/process, key steps, and audience clearly; highlights design choices and visuals from the manual; summarizes usability testing findings and major revisions; strong organization and delivery within time.	Presentation is generally clear and organized; most group members participate; covers the task/process and basic structure of the manual; mentions visuals and usability testing, but with limited detail or connection to revisions; minor	Presentation is uneven or difficult to follow; participation is unbalanced (one or two speakers dominate); limited overview of the manual; visuals not clearly explained; usability testing results are mentioned briefly or unclear; unclear organization and timing issues.	Presentation missing, extremely short, or not professional; major lack of preparation; minimal participation; fails to explain the manual clearly; no discussion of visuals or usability testing; does not meet basic requirements.	/5

Category	Excellent (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Incomplete (D/F)	Pts
		pacing or delivery issues.			
Reflection Paper/ Collaboration	Thoughtful team reflection; explains AI tool use, revisions, & individual roles	Addresses collaboration & AI use; some detail	Limited/superficial reflection	Missing or incomplete reflection	/4

TOTAL: 27%